THE DROUGHT WELL

Genre: Resource Conflict & Moral Thriller
Cultural Context: Bundelkhand / Central India (Bhojpuri / Bundeli / Malwi Context)
Characters: DEV (34), CHAUDHARY BALWANT (58), DR. ANANYA (28)

SCENE 1: EXT. THE DRY COMMONS WELL - NOON

A scorching sun beats down on cracked white earth. The air shimmers with mirages. A crowd of thirty parched villagers with empty brass lotas wait in the dust.

The deep community borewell sits inside a padlocked iron cage. A heavy forged brass padlock clamps the main discharge valve.

DEV (34), a lean mechanic with grease on his forearms and sweat stinging his eyes, adjusts a pressure gauge on the pump housing.

CHAUDHARY BALWANT (58), dressed in crisp white linen, wearing dark sunglasses and holding a heavy silver-tipped bamboo cane, leans against a luxury SUV parked under the only shade tree.

BALWANT
Tell them the aquifer is dry, Dev. If they panic, they will break the machinery.

DEV
(low, looking at the crying children in line)
The water table is fine, Chaudhary. The pressure gauge reads four hundred PSI. Why are you chaining the public tap?

BALWANT
Because fifty tankers are contracted to the industrial corridor by midnight. The government pays thirty thousand per tanker. Hand me the key to the master valve.

Dev hesitates, feeling the heavy forged iron wrench in his leather tool belt.

BALWANT
(leaning in, tapping Dev's chest with his cane)
Remember who paid your sister's hospital bail, mechanic. Give me the key.

Dev looks away, slowly handing the brass key to the landlord. Balwant locks the cage and drives off in a plume of white dust.

SCENE 2: INT. COMMUNITY CLINIC & LABORATORY - DUSK

Flickering tube lights hum. Plastic saline bottles hang from rusty stands.

ANANYA (28), a young doctor with ink-stained fingers and tired eyes, examines three test tubes holding murky brown water.

Dev knocks on the wire-mesh door and enters, wiping his grease-stained hands on a rag.

ANANYA
Seven more cholera admissions from the lower hamlet in three hours, Dev. What water did you release from the canal today?

DEV
The canal is stagnant mud, Doctor. Chaudhary locked the sweet-water deep well. He's piping twenty thousand liters an hour to the industrial estate.

ANANYA
(slamming her clipboard down)
The water in the lower hamlet well has three times the permissible arsenic level! It's poisoning them! If they don't get deep-bore sweet water tonight, three elders won't survive till sunrise.

DEV
Balwant has armed guards at the gate. If I touch that padlock, he will claim theft and the police will lock me away for ten years.

ANANYA
(pointing to an unconscious child on the cot)
Look at that child, Dev. That is your cousin's daughter. Are you a mechanic for machines, or a mechanic for people?

Dev stares at the child's feverish face. His hand slowly tightens around the iron wrench in his pocket.

SCENE 3: EXT. THE RESERVOIR & PUMP HOUSE - MIDNIGHT

Silver moonlight turns the water tank into a looming monolith. Crickets chirp in the dry thorn bushes.

Dev sneaks through the perimeter wire, gripping his heavy thirty-six-inch iron pipe wrench.

He reaches the cage. He slots the wrench jaws over the forged brass padlock. He braces his boots against the steel mesh and puts his entire body weight into the lever.

CREAK. The iron shudders.

A harsh spotlight blazes to life.

Balwant stands twenty paces away, flanked by two burly henchmen carrying wooden lathis.

BALWANT

Step away from the valve, Dev. I thought you were smarter than your father.

DEV

My father died drinking canal silt while your grandfather grew sugarcane, Chaudhary. Not tonight.

BALWANT

(signaling his men)

Break his knees. Throw him in the dry ditch.

The guards step forward. Dev doesn't run. With a thunderous grunt, he throws his full weight onto the wrench handle.

SNAP! The forged brass padlock fractures in two.

Dev yanks the high-pressure lever.

A deafening roar echoes through the valley. Pressurized, crystal-clear cold water erupts from the main relief sluice, gushing down the dry stone channel toward the village below.

In the distance, church bells and shouts of joy rise from the village as water reaches the homesteads.

Dev stands drenched in the gushing torrent, meeting Balwant's furious gaze with quiet, unbreakable resolve.

DEV

Call the police, Chaudhary. Let them come see the water.